

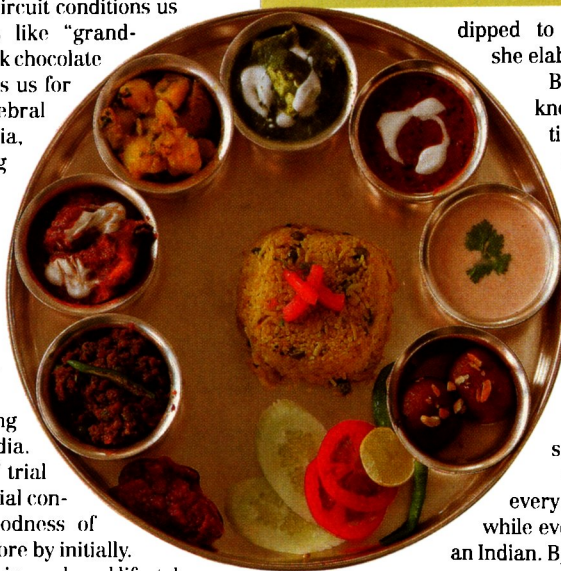
■ By Swagata Sen

Somewhere in the brain, a complex series of chemical actions and reactions is triggered off the moment we taste our first morsel. It is not clear whether the resulting circuit conditions us later to send clear messages like “grand-mother’s cooking is good” or “dark chocolate is bad”, but what follows defines us for life. Truth is, food can be a cerebral love-hate relationship. In India, food is more than just a life-long affair. It is a marriage perfected by mixing, matching, adjusting and adapting. It is a way of life that sends us sensory messages, telling us about seasons and occasions. We dance to food, we pray to food, and we have often been a country divided, or united, over food.

Food and the culture of eating have always been vital in India. Traditional diets, with years of trial and error to suit climatic and social conditions, combined with the goodness of home cooking, were what we swore by initially. However, contemporary changes in work and lifestyle patterns, urban sprawl and globalised tastes have changed all that. A food conundrum is emerging. And it’s easy to feel like a ping-pong ball, batted in one direction and then another. We are increasingly becoming suspicious of our foods, as we are getting more information. To cap it all, the diet demon has been unleashed on us.

“With the erosion of traditional family patterns and eating practices, the biggest casualty has been food,” says Delhi-based nutritionist Ishii Khosla. “We are eating far more calories from poor sources—fat of inferior quality (trans-fats)—more sugar, refined carbohydrates, more meat, preservatives and chemicals. Correspondingly, the intake of fibre, protective foods, antioxidants, vitamins and minerals has

▼ **North Indian fest:** Although mostly vegetarian, dieticians prefer this thali for its right mix of protein, carbohydrates, vitamins, calcium and iron. A common accompaniment to most Indian meals are pulses or lentils—both valuable for their high protein content.



dipped to dangerously low levels,” she elaborates.

But that is exactly the kind of knowledge that has led to a national eating crisis. We are not asking simple questions like “Am I overeating or should I skip breakfast?” Our enquiries have become more specific, to the point where we are questioning every micronutrient that constitutes a spoonful. At the same time, post-industrial Indians have become an overfed, sedentary lot.

Consider this: we have every fourth diabetic in the world, while every sixth person who dies is an Indian. By 2010, we will constitute 60

Are we eating

per cent of the world’s population which will suffer from heart attack. Around 2,000 people die of stroke everyday. These statistics, indeed, are a premonition of what is to come. However, to go back to where we were, humans have been programmed for ages to eat and eat, simply because in our hunting days, food was scarce.

India has been through its own share of famines and rationing. We have lived through massive changes in our dishes through the years. The Mughal rulers never tasted Mulligatawny soup, and the Aryans died without knowing what biryani was. Our so-called traditional thali underwent a major makeover over the last few thousand years and the very definition of it varied every 50 km or so. To someone from Jaipur, a south Indian meal strictly constituted a series of sour curries and curd, while a Bengali didn’t really care a nickel for the fluffy yellow dhokla that Gujaratis craved for. But no matter where you went in India, a meal comprised a cereal, vegetables, dairy and animal protein, chutney and a perfect sweet dish to top it all. What we had perfected was a habit. We had become



Photographs by SUVASHIS MULLICK. Location courtesy: Hotel ITC Sonar Bangla

◀ **Bangla ranna:** Most of the dishes are prepared in mustard oil, which—according to a recent study—is considered one of the best cooking mediums. This traditional meal includes fish, which is required by the body for growth of lean muscle tissue.